Blackout

By Gary Lennon

JACK: Hi, my name is Jack and I'm an alcoholic. *(pause)* Thank you. It's funny I haven't been in this room for a long time. I haven't done this in awhile. I forget where to begin. Uh…I'm so nervous. It's hard to believe I'm celebrating my seventh year of sobriety. It seems like just yesterday I was a drunk. I guess I'm still a drunk, but a dry drunk. I never thought I had a problem with alcohol.

INTRODUCTION

Overcoming an addiction to alcohol can be a long and bumpy road. At times, it may even feel impossible. But it's not. If you're ready to stop drinking and willing to get the support you need, you can recover—no matter how bad the addiction or how powerless you feel. You don't have to wait until you hit rock bottom; you can make a change at any time. Blackout by Gary Lennon takes us into the world of Alcoholics Anonymous as Jack, the leader of this particular group, shares his story.

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JACK: People were always telling me that they thought I had a drinking problem. But being Irish, I thought they were crazy. I wasn't going to give in to that. Being a drunk. I was going to defy the tyranny of fact. One of my friends said, "I think you're an alcoholic." I said, "no, not me." I thought an alcoholic was a bum, one of those guys sleeping in the streets. I was too young to be an alcoholic. I thought you at least had to be 40. Was I surprised when I hit bottom, and I woke up in the morning with somebody else's clothes on, and I didn't know how I got there. I thought an alcoholic had to drink everyday of his life. I just drank every other day.

My life has been so good since I'm sober. I'll start at the beginning for the newcomers. My advice is to stay with the program. It works. If I could stop drinking, anybody could. I know that everybody says that, but it's true. I took my first drink when I was twelve, and it seems like I never stopped. My brother got me drunk the first time. It was beer. Then it was

Boone's Farm Apple Wine. I learned about sex through Boones Farm. In P.S. 111 on a ledge. It never seemed to get better than that. I was shy. The wine loosened me up. You know what I mean.

My father was an alcoholic. He died of it. So, this is a serious disease. He died drunk. He died drunk with his face down in a puddle. He could have lived if he wanted to. If he was sober. But he was drunk. He died when I was little. And all I remember is that I hated him. I can hardly remember his face, you know, but I remember his smell. It was Jack Daniels. Me and my brothers took right after him. I don't think he meant the things he did. I don't think that he wanted me to hate him, but he could have at least told me he loved me once. No matter how drunk he was.

Both of my parents died before I was thirteen. I figured that was a good enough reason. When my mom died, I remember the night when they told me. I went out and got really drunk with my friend in the pack on 12th avenue and 51st street. We drank. I thought that if I drank so much, it would put me asleep, so that when I woke up, it wouldn't be real. She wouldn't be gone. I remember the next night I went down to the park again by myself. I brought a case with me. I drank, and there was a really bright star over the Chrysler Building, and it was watching me. I felt it. I knew it was her, and I said to it, "I don't wanna be like him," I promised. I don't want to be like him. I drank to be numb. Numb so I wouldn't feel the loss of them or feel the anger. The anger at someone or something for taking them away, because I didn't have a dad to teach me to play baseball, or teach me to fish, or teach me to be a man. I may have hated him, but I wanted him around. At least he was mine. *(pause)*

I used to have a bottle of scotch in my locker. I thought I was cool. I was kicked out twice. But they kept taking me back because my grades were so good. I was smart. I was a functioning alcoholic. I don't know how it worked. After high school, I got jobs, but I didn't keep any because they would get in the way of my career of drinking. They were good

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paying jobs too. I should have a lot of money saved, or a nice apartment, or something. I don't know where the money went. I guess I took a lot of cabs.

Relationships were a joke. Alcoholics don't have relationships. They hold hostages. It's like, "You love me, don't you? You want to suffer with me, don't you?" I was married for four months, but it was a joke. I was drinking so much at the time that I was crazy. I was seeing this girl for six months, and she started to really drive me out of my mind. As you know, alcoholics are terrified of being alone. So, I was going to jump out the window or marry her. So, I married her. I was stubborn. I never made love to anyone sober. I couldn't I always had to be drunk. I just couldn't have sex sober. So quiet. It was too scary. It was too intimate. Just you and that one other person.

My very last time being drunk was a blackout. That's when you don't remember what you do. It was a gin martini binge. Drinking did crazy things to me. I woke up in this afghan covered bed. I didn't know where I was or how I got there. I felt this strange sensation my body was going through. I couldn't life my head. I looked to the side of me, and I saw this night table. On it was a clock. I was trying to make out the time when I saw this clear glass filled with water and something pink floating in it. I looked closer. It was someone's false teeth. Pink and white. And then I heard this . . . "I met you last night at the Blarney Stone next to McDonald's on 56th and 8th Avenue." That night I went back to AA.

What I guess I'm really trying to say is that I'm grateful. I'm grateful for this room, and I'm grateful to be sober. When I first walked into this room seven years ago, I had a pint of Jack Daniels in my pocket and about a dollar fifty, and I was in ragged old clothes, and I smelled just like my father. I came in and I sat in the back. I was scared. I didn't talk to anybody. I couldn't raise my hand to say my name. I thought all of you were crazy and derelicts and you all smoked so much. I thought, "Great. All these people are getting sober, and they'll die of lung cancer." All of you were saying such personal things. I was intimidated by your honest. I said, "This place isn't for me." But I came back the next day and the next. I didn't have anywhere else to go. And the day after that and I kept coming back for 90 days. I

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came to a meeting every day, and the most important thing was I didn't drink. I didn't have to try and change my life in one day. I could do it one day at a time. I didn't say a word to any of you people, and you all shared your lives with me, telling your stories, and I thank you, because that's what kept me sober. Your stories. Just listening. You all loved me unconditionally, and you didn't even know me. You were all selfless. It's taken me 24 years to find the definition of the word's integrity, honesty, friendship, and love, and I've learned them through you. I love all of you, even the ones I don't know. You all gave me the love that I was looking for. And now, you know what? Every night at seven o'clock, I look out my window and I look up at that same star over the Chrysler Building, and I'm not drinking.

You know what the best part of being sober is? It's being able to go out with someone at night and being able to see them the next day without being humiliated about what you did or said the night before. The most important thing being sober has done for me is helping me know who I am! Who Jack is! When I was drinking, I didn't know who I was. I had spent all those years developing into a drunk person who didn't know himself. Who I didn't like. When I got sober, I asked myself, "Who are you? What makes you tick? How do you feel about that?" It's hard to be honest with yourself sometimes. So many people go around not knowing who they really are. They're afraid to ask. The answers might scare them. It's hard to take that extra moment to take a long look in the mirror and confront yourself. Do it! It's worth it.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Gary Lennon
ISBN: 978-0573662362
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 1997

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier